PUNJAB/ AKALI DAL

THE LONELINESS OF SUKHBIR BADAL

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

The Aam Aadmi Party's euphoric arrival to dominance made it the cynosure of all eyes in Punjab, but it also diverted attention from a curious void the election results had left in their wake. The Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) has been at the very fulcrum of Punjab's polity for all of its century-plus existence, and its wipeout is more than just a loss. It managed just three MLAs in the 117-seat assembly—its worst-ever electoral performance since 1967, the first polls after modern-day Punjab was carved out on linguistic lines. In a way, it's a tectonic shift, bestowing an unpredictable set of dynamics for all of Punjab—not the least for, and not only for, the Akalis.

That this has happened under Sukhbir Badal's helmsmanship brings the most urgent questions for SAD. Sukhbir himself lost from Jalalabad by almost 31,000 votes. Indeed, it seems the Badal surname—even any proximity to it—had become anathema to the people by association. Even Parkash Singh Badal, the 94-year-old family patriarch, five-time CM and Sukhbir's father, couldn't hold up against a deluge of voter anger that left no chance for nostalgia, getting washed away along with Sukhbir's brothers-in-law Adesh Pratap Kairon and Bikram Majithia, cousin Manpreet Badal (who contested as a Congressman) et al. The only survivor—from Majitha, in Majha region—was Ganieve Kaur Majithia, Bikram's wife. The Akalis lost most of their seats in the core Malwa, Phulkian and upper Malwa regions, that too by big margins.

THE BADALS DEVIATED FROM THE CORE ISSUES OF SIKHS, HENCE THE CRISIS OF CREDIBILITY IN THE AKALI DAL

Question is, will this punitive vote make the Akalis irrelevant in its bread-and-butter politics revolving around *panthic* (devout Sikh) affairs? Traditionally, the Akalis, as a party of the dominant Jat Sikhs, have served up a fare of *panth*-ism blended with regional subnationalism. In the past decade, both themes have slipped from their grip. Naturally, questions are being raised about Sukhbir's suitability for that role, besides his leadership style. No wonder he's running out of friends fast. The exit of election ally BSP was just a symptom, but the SAD Delhi unit followed suit...and now there's loud resentment in the Badal family-controlled Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC). The SAD core group, which met on March 15 in Chandigarh, didn't accept Sukhbir's resignation, but insisted his CEO style was no longer tenable and plumped for a more democratic system.

When he took over the party reins from his father in 2008, Sukhbir brought in a 'corporate culture'. Old-timers say this started the trend of the SAD moving away from core *panthic* values. Party functions happened in five-star hotels, marriages at palaces and resorts instead of gurudwara halls. And Sukhbir was more amenable to accommodating other communities than may have been deemed desirable—this time, the SAD fielded 35 Hindu candidates out of its total of 97. "For a traditional *panthic* party, this doesn't work," says Sikh historian Jagtar Sandhu, adding that the writing was on the wall, just that the Badals failed to read it.

A certain stable degree of identitarianism is perhaps crucial to such a sector—there's only so much a leader can do to dilute it. "Punjab is a state where a national minority is in a local majority. There are aspirations and issues relevant to the Sikhs. But the Badal-led SAD changed the party's culture...the mishandling of the 2015 sacrilege issue was a byproduct of this. It dented the party and family image," says Sandhu. Drug trafficking charges against SAD leaders hardly helped, nor did allegations of corruption in gurudwara funds management. Sukhbir's brother-in-law Bikram Majithia is still in Patiala Jail after his bail plea was rejected in a narcotics case. "The Akali Dal always had a pious, religious context to its existence," points out Gurdarshan Singh Dhillon, Sikh historian and former professor at Panjab University. "It has to stay sensitive to issues core to Sikhs. The Badals deviated from this, perhaps for personal gains. Hence this crisis of credibility."

What looms ahead is a battle on all fronts. Sukhbir will have to stamp his influence on the SGPC—and do it while riding out allegations that Sikh institutions are preoccupied with the SAD's political needs. Often referred to as the 'mini parliament of Sikhs', the 190-member SGPC controls the big gurudwaras in Punjab, Haryana, Chandigarh and Himachal Pradesh, and a rebellion is brewing there. SGPC general secretary Karnail Singh Panjoli has come out in the open saying